saw, he berated her for taking a break.

"*Herr Meister*," Maria said softly. "*Apotheke*?" She swallowed and pointed at her eye.

"*Nein*," he hurled back, making Maria jump. He went on speaking in German, but what Léa understood was that he had no intention of letting Maria off to go to the pharmacy.

Maria nodded, wiped her eye with her sleeve and glanced at Léa before returning her attention to the assembly line.

Maria's eye reminded Léa of when Rose had been stung by a bee once and her eye swelled like a balloon. She glanced at the clock: nearly four. The Polish women had longer shifts and worked an extra two hours. The pharmacy would be closed by the time Maria got off work. Maybe Léa could go for her. She hated how Maria and the other Polish women were treated and didn't want the only words in Maria's mind to be the awful ones that the Meister and the Lagerführer constantly muttered at her. If she could bring the medicine, then maybe it would show that not everyone thought the same. The problem wasn't Maria; it was the others. Another injustice Léa couldn't bear.

At the end of her shift, Léa met Rose downstairs. They always walked back to the barracks together. Because it was winter and the town was set in a narrow valley, dusk fell early. The snow from the previous week hadn't melted, and its bluish-gray tint reflected the cold, fading light.

"Can you believe it's only been three months?" Rose said. "It feels longer. I wish we had something to look forward to other than work." She tucked her chin in the scarf wrapped around her neck.

"Did something happen today?" Léa asked, putting her arm in Rose's.

"The Meister increased my quota. Jana said that with the colder weather, many are off sick, so the rest of us must work more."

"We can't forget we're still the lucky ones." Léa was thinking of Maria and the other Polish women. She saw the sign "*Apotheke*" up ahead and pulled Rose a little closer. "I need to get something from the pharmacy. Did you bring your ration book?"

"Yes."

"Come on." Léa opened the door, and a bell inside rang. Before entering, she wiped her boots on the mat. Rose did the same, and the bell rang again as she closed the door behind them.